

COMMUNICATIONS and BRAND MARKETING AUDIT PROGRAM #50-50-00

The release of this audit program to parties external to IBM requires the written approval of the Chief Auditor.

This program is intended as a guide for assessing risk management in this process through the performance of an audit or a similar engagement. Risk management is the process to identify, manage, and control potential events in order to provide reasonable assurance related to the achievement of IBM's business and control objectives. IBM's control objectives fall into five broad categories:

1. compliance with external laws and regulations, as well as IBM policies and procedures
2. accomplishment of business objectives
3. reliable information for financial reporting and decision making
4. efficient operations, and
5. safeguarding both intellectual and physical assets.

The control assessment questions are intended to address process objectives from the categories above and the risks to achieving those objectives. Objectives and risks in the actual process under review may differ based on organizational, operational, regulatory, and economic factors. As such, individuals performing the engagement must formulate a test strategy based on risks relative to the actual process under review, regardless of whether the risks are identified within this program.

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DATE CHANGED	SECTION #	SUBTITLE IN SECTION	CHANGED BY (NAME)	COMMENTS
March 2026	Planning	Process and Objective	Ronnie Juaño	Update the mission and objectives.
		Audit Program Risk Alignment	Ronnie Juaño	Communications: Removed the risk area related to Communication Events which will now be included in the Marketing Events auditable entity. Updated the Key Control Questions title to Financial Management and Disbursements as these sections were combined to cover test approaches for Financial Management for Communications and Disbursements for Brand Marketing. The risk area Education and Training was removed. Brand Marketing: Added the risk area table for Brand Marketing as this activity was transferred from Marketing organization to Communications. Removed Education, Training, and Separation of Duties (SOD) risk area which was originally part of the Brand Marketing risk areas.
		Data Analysis	Ronnie Juaño	Removed the sections related to Communication Events, and Education and Training. Added Disbursements.
		Self-Service Reports	Ronnie Juaño	Revised the Self-Service Reports instructions for Open Pages from WWBCIT.
	Control Assessment Questions	Supplier Management (SM001.P)	Ronnie Juaño	Updated the risks for Supplier Management and test approach.
		Financial Management and Disbursements (FM001.P)	Ronnie Juaño	Updated the risks for the combined Financial Management and Disbursements. Updated the test approaches that will cover both risk areas.
		Measurements (Data and Insights) (ME001.P)	Ronnie Juaño	Included the available measurement reports related to Brand Marketing and corresponding test approaches.
September 2025	Planning	Audit Program Risk Alignment	CA&AS Ops	Changes to audit risk levels from recent revalidation
December 2024	Planning	Audit Program Risk Alignment	Ronnie Juaño	CEO Events Risk Area was removed and updated to Communication Events. CEO Events will now be covered in Marketing and Events.
	Planning	Data Analysis	Ronnie Juaño	Updated the analysis for CEO Events to Communication Events
	Planning	Reference Materials	Ronnie Juaño	Included a link to MCC Homepage and Analyst Relations
	Control Assessment Questions	EC001.P, IM001.P, CE001.P, ME001.P, IC001.P	Ronnie Juaño	Updated control assessment questions to remove outdated test questions and reflect removal of CEO Events, recategorize a test question from External Communications to Issues Management, include a definition for Data & Insights. Included a reference to Internal Communications as synonymous to IBMer Communications.

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November 2023	Planning	Self-Service Reports	Ronnie Juaño	Added Self-Service Reports section
May 2, 2023	Section 3 and 4	Reference Material; Control Assessment Questions on Data Privacy and Security (Risk Exposures)	Ronnie Juaño	Update the links to reference materials; updated the risk exposure for data privacy and security section
April 2023	DP001.P	Data Privacy and Data Protection	Don Dobrzelewski	Added Privacy Testing
February 2023	All	All	CA&AS	Converted from Notes into a Word document and into a Box folder

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PROCESS AND OBJECTIVE

The mission of Corporate Affairs & Brand is to accelerate IBM's growth by advancing and defending our reputation, persuading external and internal audiences, and driving brand consideration. This is done by illustrating IBM's strategy, innovation and industry leadership with clients, investors, media, analysts, employees, policy influencers, and other key stakeholders.

The goal is to build belief in IBM as:

- **An enterprise AI leader** - "Most advanced and trusted for AI in business"
- **An innovative pioneer** creating the next computing paradigm - "Leading the shift from consumer AI hype to enterprise AI value and pioneering the quantum era that follows."
- **Modern and approachable** - "Easy to work with, less bureaucratic, contemporary culture"
- **Trusted for mission-critical complexity** - "The experts who handle the world's most critical infrastructure and hardest technical challenges"

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PLANNING: Audit Program Risk Alignment

Communications

Defined Risk Area	Audit Risk Level	Key Control Question	Test Number
External Communications	High	External Communications	EC001.P
Issue Management	High	Issue Management	IM001.P
Data Privacy and Data Security	High	Data Privacy and Data Security	DP001.P
Financial Management	Medium	Financial Management and Disbursements	FM001.P
Measurements	Medium	Measurements – Data and Insights	ME001.P
Supplier Management	Medium	Supplier Management	SM001.P
Internal Communications	Low	Internal Communications	IC001.P

Brand Marketing

Defined Risk Area	Audit Risk Level	Key Control Question	Test Number
Disbursements	Medium	Financial Management and Disbursements	FM001.P
Supplier Management	Medium	Supplier Management	SM001.P
Data Privacy and Protection	Medium	Data Privacy and Data Security	DP001.P
Measurements	Medium	Measurements	ME001.P

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PLANNING: Data Analysis

Data analysis should be a part of every engagement where data is available in databases or data warehouses that can be accessed through query programs. This concept enhances the risk-based auditing approach, makes the audit process more efficient, and increases the productivity of the audit team. When the audit team does not have the skills required to perform these tasks, assistance should be sought from the Technology team.

All data used for analysis must be reconciled to an independent source so that the auditor has confidence that the universe is complete.

The [Data Analysis engagement procedures in the Audit Manual](#) (link internal to CA&AS members only) provide further suggestions.

This table shows what data can be reviewed and analysis techniques.

Data to be Analyzed	Analysis to be Performed	Concern
External Communication List of all Press Releases, Announcements, Annual Report that were produced (published) during the audit period.	Select samples of press releases produced during the audit period to validate if: - Press release had all designed approvals. - Published version of the communication matches the approved communication.	Improper communication management could damage IBM image and reputation. It could also expose IBM compliance with regulations.
Issue Management List of all the issues identified during the audit period, including: - Level - Description - Original date, identification date and closed date	For issue management validate if: - The timeliness and appropriateness of reaction to issue as well as the supporting documentation and tracking of follow-ups. - There was a process in place to monitor responses, for communications loaded into an environment where external parties could upload opinions, points of view, or comments. - Issues were timely reported to management, and ensure that corrective actions, if applicable, were taken. - The defined criteria for media monitoring were reasonable to the business and how the key words to be monitored were selected.	Improper communication management could damage IBM image and reputation. It could also expose IBM compliance with regulations.

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PLANNING: Data Analysis (Continued)

Data to be Analyzed	Analysis to be Performed	Concern
Supplier Management A list of all active contracts/SOW signed during the audit period. Report of all payments made to suppliers during the audit period. (Accounts Payable).	Review a sample of supplier management to validate if: • Selected suppliers were approved. • Services were received, and payments were done according to contract terms and conditions. • Delivery monitoring was performed. • Detected conflicts of interests were resolved. • SOW requirements were timely attended. • Unused advanced funds were not credited to other projects and if they were returned promptly to IBM.	Improper use of budget and ineffective supplier management could lead to financial losses, unauthorized payments, and supplier dissatisfaction.
Financial Management and Disbursements Financial Plan versus Actual List of all invoices/PO during the audit period	Review a sample of financial management to verify if: • The infrastructure and program budget versus actuals were accurate and reasonable. In case of deviations, if they were detected, analyzed, and adjusted or supported.	Improper use of budget and ineffective supplier management could lead to financial losses, unauthorized payments, and supplier dissatisfaction.
Measurements (Data and Insights) List and copy of all measurements for the audit period.	Review samples of key measurements to validate if: • Measurements (Data and Insights) were obtained from valid and accurate resources and how the key attributes/measures were selected. • There was management visibility to critical/key measurements. • Action plans have been discussed and/or implemented (as necessary) to address performance trends.	Inadequate key measurements (Data and Insights) and controls could impair management decision making.

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PLANNING: Data Analysis (Continued)

Data to be Analyzed	Analysis to be Performed	Concern
Data Privacy and Security	For all risk areas tested, review if IBM assets, sensitive personal information, confidential information, and customer proprietary information, if applicable, were properly protected according to IBM guidelines.	The failure to protect IBM Confidential and other sensitive information could lead to regulatory non-compliance, commercial disadvantages, and expose IBM reputation.
Internal (or IBMer) Communications List of all internal (or IBMer) communications published during the audit period.	Review samples of internal (or IBMer) communications to verify if: Global internal (or IBMer) communications were reviewed and approved prior to being published.	Inaccurate or controversial internal (or IBMer) communications could result in messages reaching external parties. It also could damage IBM reputation and lead to employee's dissatisfaction

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PLANNING: Reference Material

Brand Marketing homepage:

<https://w3.ibm.com/w3publisher/brand-marketing-asset-repository>

FIN168 - Business Amenities and Gifts

<https://w3.ibm.com/ibm/corporate-documents/fin/fin-168-leg-168>

FIN101 - Control of Disbursements

<https://w3.ibm.com/ibm/corporate-documents/fin/fin-101>

LEG116 - Classification and control of IBM information

<https://w3.ibm.com/ibm/corporate-documents/leg/leg-116>

FIN182 - Management Self Assessment of Control

<https://w3.ibm.com/ibm/corporate-documents/fin/fin-182>

Marketing and Communications Homepage

<https://w3.ibm.com/w3publisher/the-new-c-c-and-marketing-team>

IBM News Room

<https://newsroom.ibm.com>

IBM w3 News

<https://w3.ibm.com/#/news>

Analyst Relations

<https://w3.ibm.com/w3publisher/ibm-analyst-relations>

CTEBA website

<https://w3.ibm.com/w3publisher/cteba>

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PLANNING: Fraud Template

Fraud is any intentional act or omission designed to deceive others and resulting in the victim suffering a loss and/or the perpetrator achieving a gain. Fraud can be categorized into fraudulent financial reporting, misappropriation of assets, and improper or unauthorized expenditures.

Description of Fraud Risk	Typical Controls that should Detect the Fraud Risk	Testing Approach
Improper use of IBM budget for events	Program reconciliation and PO tracking and monitoring	Test if reconciliation was performed on time and ensure PO are used as intended.
Unauthorized use of supplier/ Procurement bypasses	Suppliers must be approved before being contracted	Test if Procurement was involved in supplier selection and contracting

Note: Likelihood and impact will vary depending on the organization/business unit that is being audited. Additionally, financial reconciliation could be done at a program level instead of at an event level.

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PLANNING: Self-Service Reports

Some information previously included in the Initial Data Request (IDR) items which continue to be relevant information in audits will now be extracted directly by the audit team. These are as follows:

Information previously in IDR	Instructional Materials to download information and applying for access to the source tool
• Management Self-Assessment (MSA) • Risk Assessments/Acceptances • List of Statement of Work (SOW)	Self-Serve Reports for Communications

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CONTROL ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS

Key Control Question: 1. External Communications

Objective:

To ensure that the release of communications to external parties is aligned with IBM's objectives and is approved at the right level prior to any message being distributed to the external environment. In some cases, a Legal approval must be necessary for certain messages to the external community.

Risk/Exposure:

The release of unapproved communications could expose IBM image, result in misuse or wrong messages shared and could impact IBM's reputation in the marketplace.

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CONTROL ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS

Key Control Question: 1. External Communications

Primary Test: External Communications (EC001.P)

Objective:

To ensure that the release of communications to external parties is aligned with IBM's objectives and is approved at the right level prior to any message being distributed to the external environment. In some cases, a Legal approval must be necessary for certain messages to the external community.

Approach:

Select a sample of external communications to third parties during the audit period and test the following:

1. Was there an approval process in place for external communications? Was that process reviewed and updated on a regular basis?
2. Were all communications released to external parties during the audit period properly reviewed and approved at the right level before the release date?
3. Was there a process in place to track cases where this approval was not in place? Were corrective actions taken? Was there a reporting process in place to inform management on a periodic basis?
4. Was there a process in place to detect and report the cases when the approved communication was a different version of the one published?
5. If communications were put in a public environment, were there controls in place to ensure the content is not or cannot be altered by unauthorized parties? Are security measures in place to avoid unauthorized access to the message?
6. Is there a process in place to ensure that communications are loaded into a secure IT environment?

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CONTROL ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS

Key Control Question: 2. Issue Management

Objective:

Determine if adequate controls were in place to identify issues timely and act accordingly in order to protect IBM's brand.

Risk/Exposure:

Failure to react to a mention in print, on social media, or broadcast could impact IBM's reputation and ability to address the situation.

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CONTROL ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS

Key Control Question: 2. Issue Management

Primary Test: Issue Management (IM001.P)

Objective:

Determine if adequate controls were in place to identify issues timely and act accordingly in order to protect IBM's brand.

Approach:

1. Is there a management system in place to report communication issues/risks and deviations to expected feedback or business goals?
2. Were the issues identified and the threat level classified correctly and timely?
3. Did the issues council activate timely the Issue Response Process?
4. Were the defined strategic direction and tactics adequate to be used according to level of the issues? Were the tactics defined, the ones performed? Was the defined strategy timely documented?
5. According to the duration of the issues was it frequently (as defined in the process) monitored, reassessed, and new tactics defined as needed?
6. If communications are loaded into an environment where external parties can upload opinions, points of view, or comments, is there a process in place to detect improper or negative contents, report them to management, and ensure that corrective action, if decided as applicable, is taken?

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CONTROL ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS

Key Control Question: 3. Supplier Management

Objective:

Validate if supplier assessment is being effectively and accurately executed and controlled according to Procurement's guidelines. To address business risk, protect IBM's interests, to ensure that the best value was received for IBM, and procurement bypass did not occur.

Risk/Exposure:

Failure to engage with suppliers according to procurement guidelines could impact IBM's image and result in excess expenditures, supplier relations exposures, and can lead to fraud.

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CONTROL ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS

Key Control Question: 3. Supplier Management

Primary Test: Supplier Management (SM001.P)

Objective:

Validate if supplier assessment is being effectively and accurately executed and controlled according to Procurement's guidelines. To address business risk, protect IBM's interests, to ensure that the best value was received for IBM, and procurement bypass did not occur.

Approach:

1. Was the procurement organization formally and timely involved in the supplier selection process for new suppliers or during renegotiations?
2. Was there no commitment to the supplier prior to the completion of the supplier selection process?
3. Determine if management had procedures in place to prevent the bypass of procurement. If a bypass did occur, validate that control procedures were implemented in a timely manner to ensure that repeat bypasses would be prevented. If applicable, review any control risk assessment (CRA) measurements that the organization may have in place for procurement bypasses.
4. Did the contract have all required terms and conditions, as well as appropriate clauses?
5. Were deliverables clearly defined and were supplier performance measurements specified in the contract? When changes occurred, were there controls in place to identify updates to the scope of work?
6. Were proper management approvals (e.g., legal, taxes, procurement, financial, human relations, etc.) obtained, as appropriate, before the start of work and prior to any contract creation, alterations, and extensions?
7. Were the requisitions and purchase orders properly approved and the same as the committed value?
8. Were there accruals to reflect invoices not received from suppliers at month close?

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CONTROL ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS

Key Control Question: 4. Financial Management and Disbursements

Objective:

To determine whether an effective process existed to ensure expenses that were incurred for an event/program were accurate according to approval, within budget, and in compliance with IBM policies. To ensure that disbursements follow the supplier contract, and they are valid, verified, approved, and paid in a timely manner.

Risk/Exposure:

Improper use of budget for Communications and Brand Marketing could lead to financial loss or unauthorized payments.

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CONTROL ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS

Key Control Question: 4. Financial Management and Disbursements

Primary Test: Financial Management and Disbursements (FM001.P)

Objective:

To determine whether an effective process existed to ensure expenses that were incurred for the program were accurate according to approval, within budget, and in compliance with IBM policies. To ensure that disbursements follow the supplier contract, and they are valid, verified, approved, and paid in a timely manner.

Approach:

Request a list of closed programs for the audit period, request previous budget approval, and ask for the event/program reconciliation documents and related disbursements, and test if:

1. Verification of Goods/Services

- Confirm goods/services were performed/delivered as committed in the contract/SoW. Ensure the billing aligns with the contracted scope and commitments.
- Verify delivery occurred after PO release or contract signature.

2. Budget Approval & Alignment

- Ensure the budget was approved prior to the activity (program/project). Confirm all expenses align with the approved budget.

3. Reconciliation Process

- Confirm a process exists to reconcile financials. Verify that the reconciliation was performed after completion of work, prior to payment of final balance.
- The program reconciliation should be performed after the program is finished (within 90 days after the program end date).

4. Invoice & Payment Controls

- Validate invoice details (price, quantity, rates) and confirm it matches with commitment info (SoW/PO/contract).
- Check if Invoice Payment Verification (or equivalent) and notification steps were performed before payment. Test a sample of credits to ensure they were properly applied.

5. PO & Commitment Management

- Determine whether payments exceed PO commitments. If they do, confirm there is tracking, reconciliation, and approval of variances.

6. Parked/Leftover Funds

- Identify any "parked funds" with suppliers. Ensure all excess funds are returned, not carried forward or credited to future work unless formally re-approved. Verify timely return and proper accounting treatment.

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CONTROL ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS

Key Control Question: 6. Measurements (Data and Insights)

Objective:

To determine if measurements are in place and functioning which provide management/executives indicators of brand visibility and the organization's reputation and relevance in the market.

Risk/Exposure:

Inaccurate or incomplete measurements could hinder management's ability to make key decisions. This could lead to sub-optimal resource allocations, budget overages, or failure to detect inappropriate activities.

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CONTROL ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS

Key Control Question: 6. Measurements (Data and Insights)

Primary Test: Measurements (Data and Insights) (ME001.P)

Objective:

To determine if measurements are in place and functioning which provide management/executives indicators of brand visibility and the organization's reputation and relevance in the market.

Data and Insights Definition: For External Communications, Data and Insights are focused on earned media and earned social. These efforts are focused on strengthening our AI leadership and relevance by expanding our awareness and consideration to ensure the message resonates with our audience who repeat and are positive. The same type of measurements (data and insights) for Internal Communications, Analyst Relations, and other relevant activities within the Communications organization should be reviewed as part of the engagement (if applicable).

The Communications team evaluates:

- Volume - number of articles or posts.
- Reach - sum of all potential audiences that could see a given communication, dependent on the channel used to communicate.
- Key Message Pull Through - how many key messages are included in earned media results that resonate with our audience

Approach:

Review measurement reporting for the following:

1. Were the measurements obtained from valid and reliable resources?
2. Was the measurements calculation accurate?
3. Was there management visibility to all measurements? Have you documented any exceptional decision to invalidate it to be measured? Have action plans been implemented to correct unfavorable trends?
4. Was there a lesson learned in place for the Communication events to evaluate the outcomes?

The Brand Marketing team utilizes a variety of measurement tools, including but not limited to:

- Brand Health Monitor (BHM) – Primary source for tracking IBM's brand perception and competitive position among enterprise buyers, users, and decision makers.
- Ad Testing – Validates message clarity, relevance, and creative effectiveness prior to launch.
- In-Market Measurement – Provides real-time insight into overall campaign performance, including channel, placement, audience, format, and creative variations.
- Paid Media Reach & Frequency – Quarterly diagnostic used to confirm whether media delivery levels are sufficient to achieve desired outcomes.

Approach:

Review measurement reporting for the following:

1. What are your data sources, and is the data used for calculations reliable?
2. Is the measurement methodology aligned with the process objective?
3. Is management properly reviewing all reports?
4. Do you have a predefined action plan to respond to findings?

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CONTROL ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS

Key Control Question: 7. Data Privacy and Data Security

Objective:

IBM assets, sensitive personal information, confidential information, and customer proprietary information, if applicable, were properly protected.

Risk/Exposure:

Failure to properly protect information and assets from unauthorized usage or access.

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CONTROL ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS

Key Control Question: 7. Data Privacy and Data Security

Primary Test: Data Privacy and Data Security (DP001.P)

Objective:

IBM assets, sensitive personal information, confidential information, and customer proprietary information, if applicable, were properly protected.

Approach:

For all risk area tested:

1. Review if IBM assets, sensitive personal information, confidential information, and customer proprietary information, if applicable, were properly protected.

Test: Privacy

Objective:

Privacy laws impose requirements on how IBM and its Clients process Personal Information (PI). The Global Privacy Control Assessment Questions are composed with two key areas of the business to help address compliance with these various high-level laws.

- **IBM as a Controller** – The Enterprise Privacy Baseline – Controller establishes the high-level requirements that IBM must meet when acting as a Controller of Personal Information (PI). That is, PI that IBM collects and processes for its own purposes, such as Business Contact Information that IBM holds on its existing or potential customers or suppliers.
- **IBM as a Processor** – The Enterprise Privacy Baseline – Processor establishes the principles and requirements that IBM must meet when acting as a Processor of Client Personal Information (PI) and applies to all products, offerings, and services (including their components) that IBM provides to Clients, regardless of whether IBM develops or re-brands them, or provides them for a fee or on a beta, trial, or no-charge basis.

Approach:

Review the Data Privacy responses provided from the Initial Data Request. Determine if IBM is Controller or Processor of PI/SPI data in the process.

Testing:

IBM as Controller

If IBM is Controller, request a risk-based sample of Global Privacy Assessments for the processes and/or assets. Complete the testing from the following link: <https://ibm.ent.box.com/file/1198251968388>

IBM as Processor

If IBM is Processor, select a sample of products/offerings/services provided for the in-scope activities. Complete the testing from the following link: <https://ibm.ent.box.com/file/1198263127550>

IBM as both Controller and Processor

Test either IBM as Controller or Processor, do not test both. Consider the volume and sensitivity of the controller and processor data and select the higher risk.

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CONTROL ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS

Key Control Question: 8. Internal Communications

Objective:

To ensure internal (or IBMer) communications were developed and approved.

Risk/Exposure:

Risk of creating false or unapproved statements that could impact employee morale, engagement, or that might be leaked to outside / external parties.

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CONTROL ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS

Key Control Question: 8. Internal Communications

Primary Test: Internal Communications (IC001.P)

Objective:

To ensure internal (or IBMer) communications were developed and approved.

Approach:

1. Were the internal (or IBMer) communications reviewed and approved prior to being published?
2. If there were any exceptions noted in the communications process, what were the causes and what controls and action plan implemented to mitigate future occurrences?